ourselves not to their humanity but to their self-love, and never talk to them of our own necessities, but of their advantages.' Smith was seeking to convert the relationship of producers of food and consumers of food into an economic and business relationship where both parties act in their self-interest.

Agriculture has done well in India in the past seventy-four years. However, the lot of farmers in general still remains miserable. Governments have tried numerous agriculture development and input subsidization programmes and provided price and output protection. Yet, the largest proportion of the poor in India comes from the farming community: small and marginal farmers and landless farm labour. Government programmes have totally missed heeding the advice of Adam Smith to make farmers work in self-interest. Farming needs to become a business for farmers to have any chance of becoming prosperous.

Let us look at how the economics of onions works in India.

Onionomics: Once in Two to Three Years, Onion Prices Bring Tears to Consumers

In December 2019, the price of onions crossed Rs 100, on average, in many retail markets; they were even sold at over Rs 200 per kg in some places. Prices fell soon and onions were selling at just Rs 10 per kg after a few months. Once every two to three years, onion prices bring tears to the eyes of consumers. However, such episodes do not last for more than two to three months at best.

After Prime Minister Indira Gandhi exploited the onion price rise to topple the Janata government in 1980, the price of onions has become a political hot potato! The high prices of onions, which India produces in surplus and exports, lead to much breast-beating, breaking news in the media and chart-topping memes on social media. Invariably, the government panics as if the country were in the midst of a major economic